Text Field - Form Formatting

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Best Practices

Structure
Consider your form structure in a strategic way — what's the best way to structure your form to improve user experience? Think about the order in which your fields appear, the form's appearance on your web page, and how your fields and sections flow from one to another.

Proximity
Always consider the law of proximity when constructing form flows. Use white space to drive user understanding. Semantically group items based on related content.

Hierarchy
Use Headings and Labelling appropriately to support progressive form completion. This also applies to ordering forms in a logical manner. Consider what information should come first and align with conceived user mental models.

Simplicity
Remove all non-essential fields. Only ever ask the most relevant information. If a user is already a Telstra customer it's likely they've provided important information - allow them to login to streamline user input requirements.

Consistency
Forms should follow a similar (if not the same) structure across digital products. Where possible - consider templating a forms structure and relying on this so users don't have to unlearn / re-learn an input flow.

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Field Length

Visual constraints help drive user understanding. Different field widths serve as a good anchor for eyes to navigate faster than in a column with the fields of the same width. When possible, use field length as an affordance.

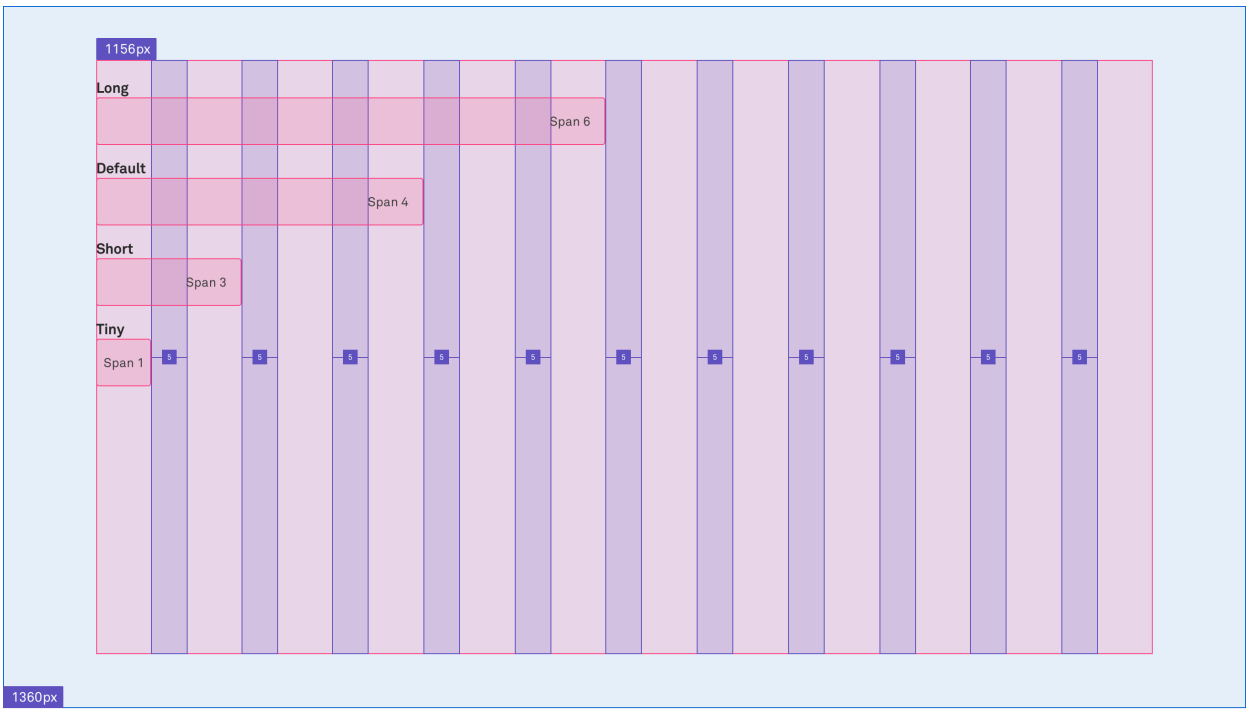
The length of an input field should be in proportional to the amount of information expected in the field. The size of the field will act as a visual constraint—the user will know how much text is expected to be entered just by looking at the field. Generally, fields such as ones for post codes and house numbers should be shorter than ones for street addresses.

The Able Design System recommends the following:

1. Auto - set to automatically size to character input
2. Long
3. Default
4. Short
5. Tiny

These are available in the Web catalogue and as a design recommendation for iOS and Android. Specs can be found in the Able Sketch Sticker Sheets.

Example shown: Viewport MD



Span refers to grid columns. Span3 = 3 of 12 columns

Alias	ViewportXS	ViewportSM	ViewportMD	ViewportLG
Auto	Fit to input's max width			
Long	Span12	Span12	Span6	Span6

Default ⚠️	Span12	Span6	Span4	Span4
Short	Span6	Span4	Span2	Span2
Tiny	Span3	Span2	Span1	Span1

Stacking

Single and Multi Column Stacking

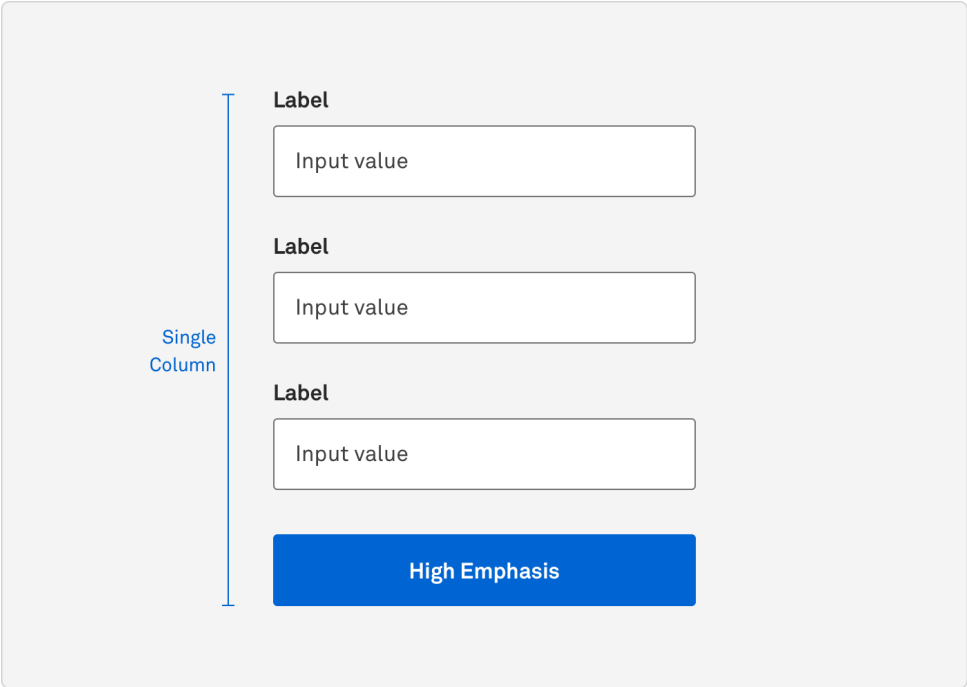
Form field layouts should be organised in a single stack / column versus placing multiple fields in the same row or in various locations. Visitors will easily see all necessary fields and have the ability to tab down to the next open box if they choose to work through the form that way. Multiple columns disrupts a users vertical momentum.

However related fields with shorter input requirements may be placed in multiple columns where. When considering a multi column form - consider if this content would make sense in a sentence. If it does not - it must be in a single stack.

Some examples of the exceptions to this rule include:

- City / State / Postcode
- Title / Name
- Birthday (Month, Date, Year)

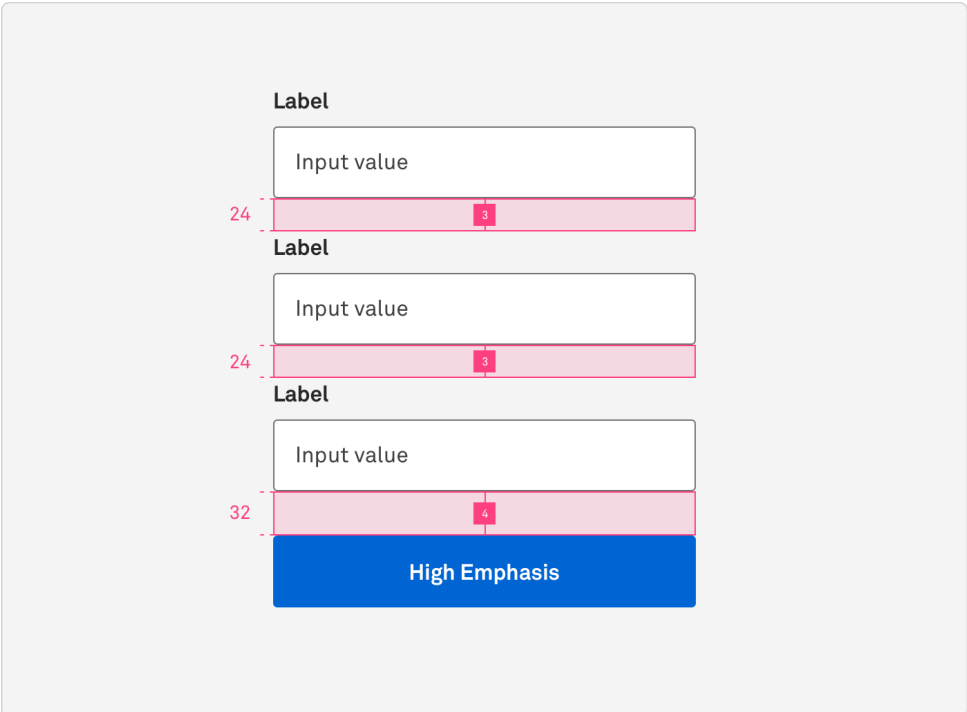
Please note: This is only recommended on larger viewports as smaller viewports have limited space. For example always use single stacking for a mobile display.



Form Spacing

Related Form Elements

Consider the laws of proximity when building a form. Use smaller padding to indicate related form items.

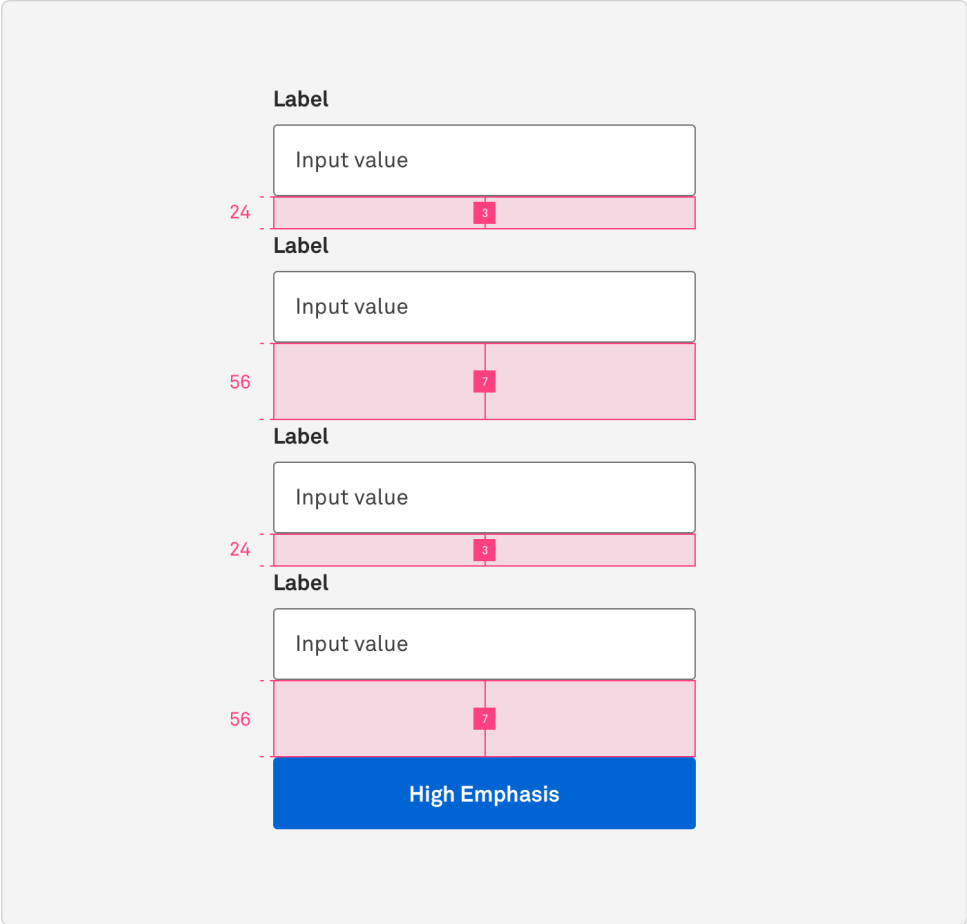


Semantic Grouping Form Elements

Group form elements with headings and larger spacing to indicate separate form items. Where possible it is recommended to create multi-page forms to simplify user inputs per screen (see below).

However if it is desired for a form to exist on a single page, ensure content grouping clearly communicates related content items.

If there are a lot of fields in a form, try to divide them into semantic groups by adding some additional spaces or section titles between them. This approach gives a respondent the feeling of gradual answering.



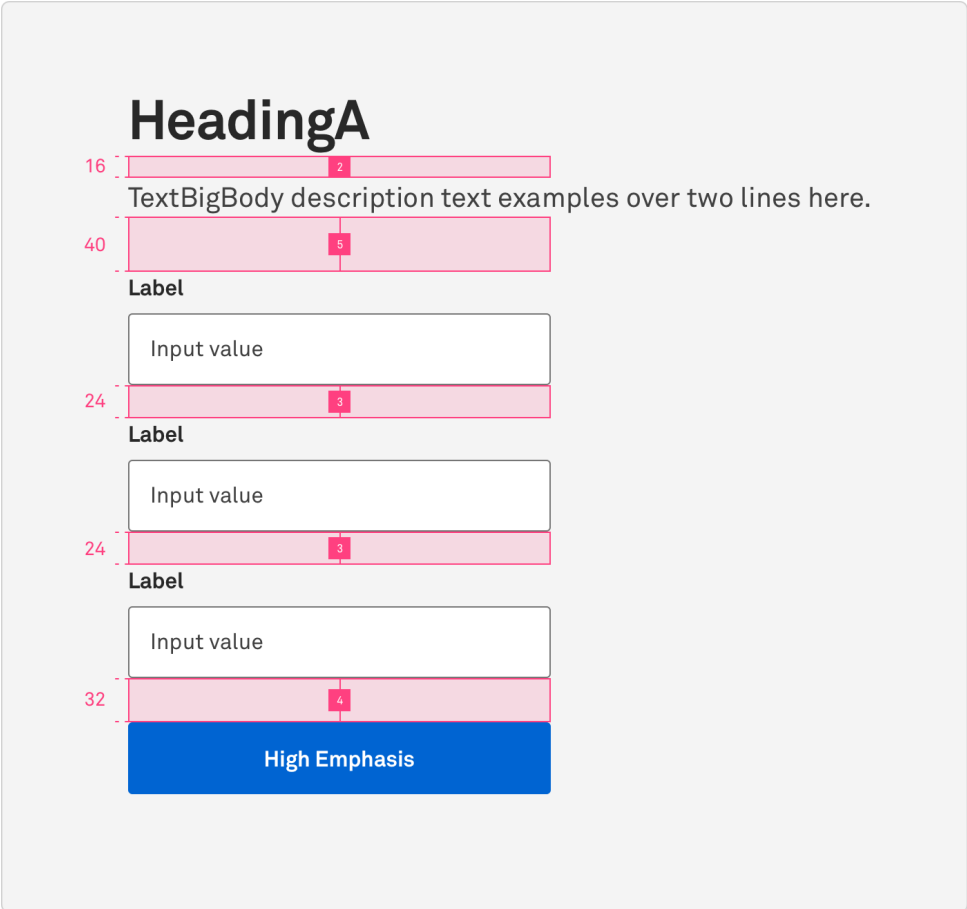
Text Pairing

Heading A

Heading A can be used for hero forms. These are forms that are a major part of the user journey and require additional emphasis.

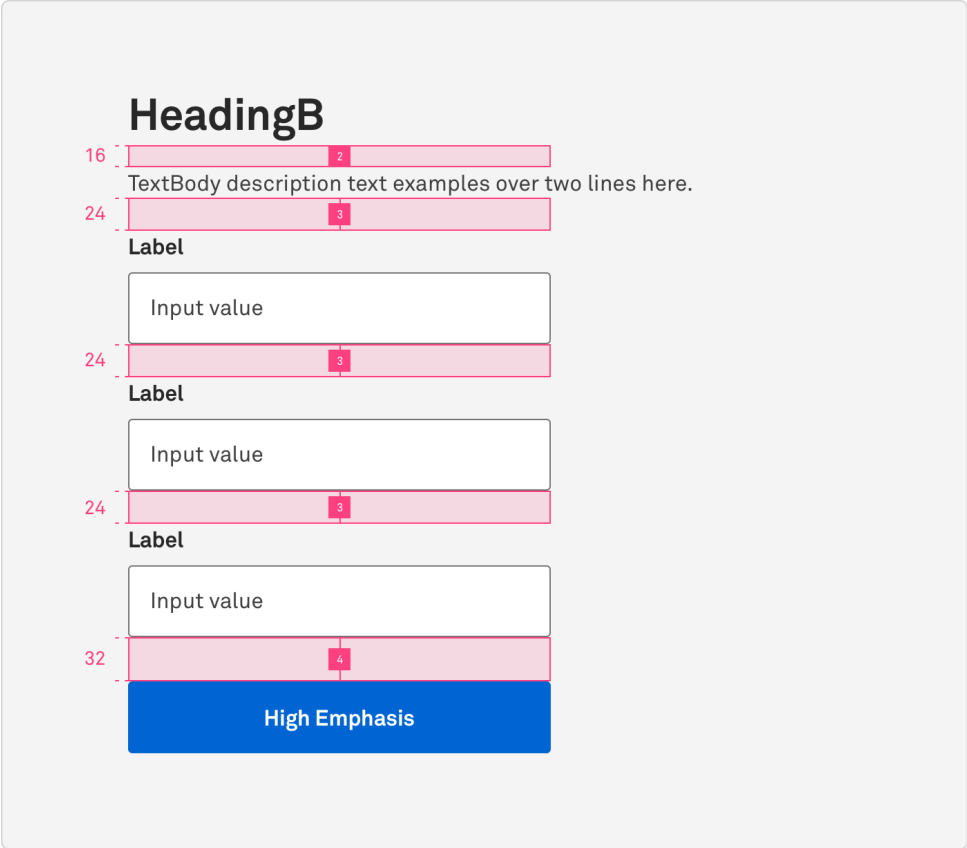
Examples may include:

- Onboarding
- Sign up for Telstra ID



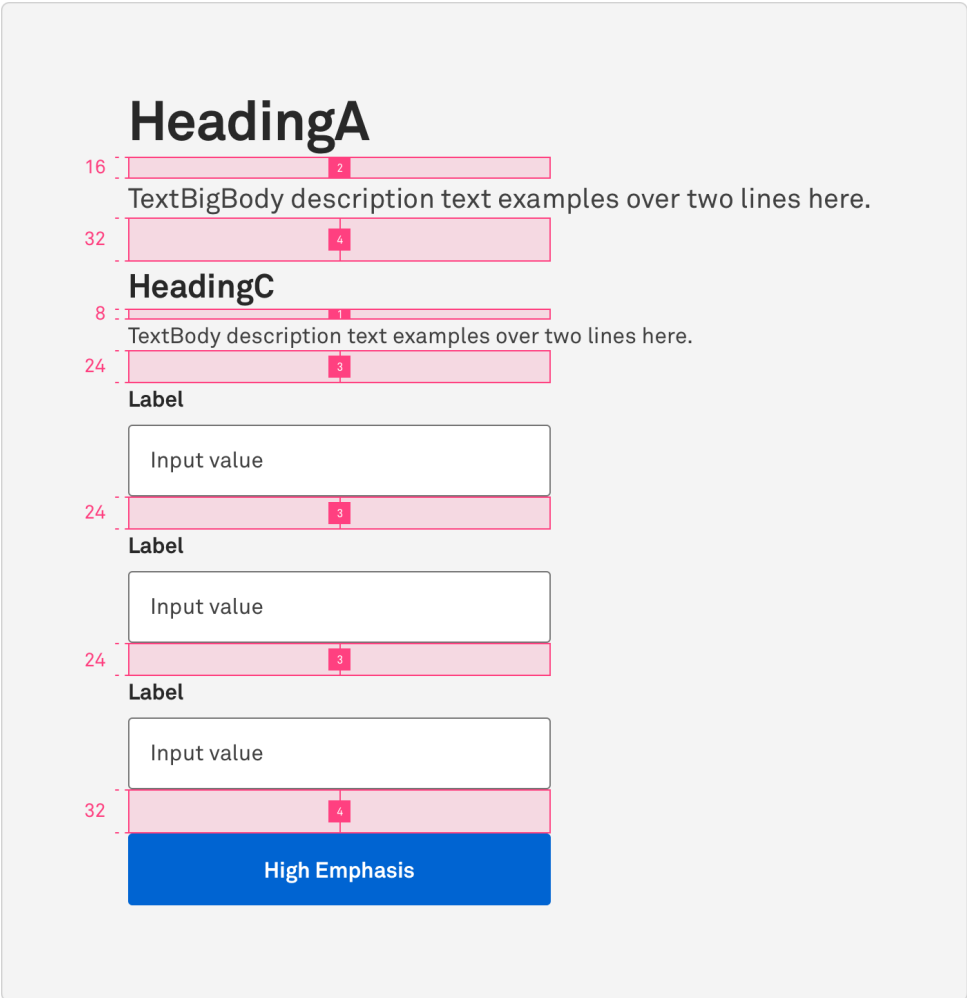
Heading B

Heading B is the default recommendation for forms.



Heading C

Please note Heading C is recommended for long single page forms with multiple groupings. Pair with Heading A introduction copy.



Multi-step Forms

Multi-step forms are used in situations where there are multiple form fields, several of which could be split up into categories (such as “personal”, “shipping”, “billing”, and “payment review”).

They improve UX because they increase a form’s usability by making it easier for a visitor to accomplish their goal (completing and submitting the form). With a multi-step form, you split your fields into several shorter forms, each on separate web pages. They help to organise your form fields and make the form appear more manageable for the user.

No labels

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